agent.’ He was also told that he had no authority to offer any money or an alliance to the Kandahar Barakzais, and his initiative to try and buy their support was disowned and countermanded.

In particular Auckland continued to show a complete lack of interest in the idea of an alliance with Kabul, as he made very clear in the letter he addressed to Dost Mohammad. Auckland told the Amir he must forget Peshawar and ‘relinquish the idea of governing that territory’. He must also ‘desist from all intercourse with Persia, Russia and Turkistan’. All the British would do in return, ‘which is all I think that can in justice be granted’, would be to persuade the Sikhs not to invade Kabul and so save the Amir ‘from a ruinous war’. Ranjit Singh for his part ‘through the generosity of his nature has acceded to my wish for the cessation of strife, if you should behave in a less mistaken manner to him. It becomes you earnestly to think on the mode in which you may effect reconciliation with that powerful prince, to whom my nation is united by the direct bonds of friendship, and to abandon hopes which cannot be realised.’

Finally there was a warning: if Dost Mohammad should continue to consort with Persia and Russia, the Indian government would support Sikh expansion into Afghanistan and ‘Captain Burnes . . . will retire from Kabul where his further stay cannot be advantageous’.[93] There was not the slightest hint of compromise to meet Dost Mohammad’s entirely legitimate anxieties and aspirations. Instead Auckland had actually hardened his position against the Amir, who was now being told he could not correspond with Persia and Russia except with British permission, that he must surrender all claims to Peshawar and Kashmir and, most unpalatable of all, beg Ranjit Singh for forgiveness.

It was difficult to see how Burnes could salvage anything from this suicidal set of instructions, especially when Russia was prepared to offer so much: not only friendship and protection, but two million roubles in hard cash to raise an army against the Sikhs – everything Dost Mohammad wished for. In an apparent fit of absent-mindedness, Auckland had in a single stroke handed over to the Russians a great swathe of territory from Persia through Central Asia to Afghanistan – something Vitkevitch realised as soon as he came to hear of the letters’ contents. ‘The British’, he wrote, ‘are losing for a long time any hope of re-establishing their influence in this area.’[94]